

Performance-Based Learning & Instructional Design

Reflective Application Report

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1. Purpose of This Report

The purpose of this report is to demonstrate understanding and application of the key instructional concepts presented in the FQAS Curriculum session. This includes performance-based learning, curriculum alignment using Bloom's Taxonomy, assessment design, rubric development, feedback strategies, universal design for learning (UDL), and the use of data to inform instructional decisions.

Rather than restating definitions, this report focuses on how these concepts interrelate and how they can be applied in a real instructional context.

2. Performance-Based Learning: From Concept to Application

Performance-based learning was presented as an approach centered on **authentic, meaningful tasks** that require students to demonstrate their knowledge through action.

The most important insight for me was the distinction between:

- *covering content*
- *versus*
- *demonstrating capability*

In practice, this shifts the instructional question from:

“What should students know?”

to:

“What should students be able to do, and how will they demonstrate it?”

This aligns strongly with technical education, where the goal is not only knowledge acquisition but the ability to apply that knowledge in real-world contexts.

3. Maslow's Hierarchy and Student Readiness

The review of Maslow's Hierarchy reinforced that student performance is not purely academic—it is conditional.

A key takeaway is that:

Student performance is often constrained by unmet foundational needs rather than lack of ability.

This reframes instructional challenges. When a student struggles, the question becomes:

- Is this a knowledge gap?
- Or is this a capacity constraint (time, stress, financial pressure, etc.)?

This awareness supports more empathetic and adaptive instructional design.

4. Bloom's Taxonomy and Curriculum Alignment

Bloom's Taxonomy provided a practical framework for aligning curriculum with performance-based learning.

The session emphasized:

- Using **higher-order verbs** (evaluate, analyze, create) for competencies
- Using lower-order verbs (define, describe) as supporting steps

The key insight here is:

The verb defines the level of thinking expected.

This has direct implications for both:

- how competencies are written
- how assessments are designed

If the competency uses a high-level verb, the assessment must require that same level of thinking.

5. Assessment Design: Formative and Summative Balance

The distinction between formative and summative assessment clarified their complementary roles:

- **Formative assessment** supports learning during the process
- **Summative assessment** evaluates cumulative understanding

A key insight is that formative assessment acts as:

real-time feedback for both the student and the instructor

while summative assessment answers:

“Did the learning persist and integrate?”

The strongest examples from the session involved:

- real-world scenarios
- applied problem-solving
- synthesis of multiple concepts

These align directly with performance-based learning principles.

6. Rubrics as Communication Tools

A significant shift in perspective for me was viewing rubrics not just as grading tools, but as:

explicit communication mechanisms

A well-designed rubric:

- clarifies expectations

- reduces ambiguity
- supports consistent evaluation
- enables targeted feedback

In practice, this means that a rubric should:

- reflect the competency
 - define observable performance
 - guide both student effort and instructor feedback
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7. Feedback as a Development Tool

The discussion on feedback highlighted its dual role:

- evaluation
- and development

The most impactful takeaway was the structure of effective feedback:

- start with positive reinforcement
- follow with constructive guidance
- provide actionable next steps

This approach improves:

- student receptiveness
- confidence
- and ability to improve

Feedback, when done well, becomes an extension of instruction rather than a separate activity.

8. Universal Design for Learning (UDL)

Universal Design for Learning reframes instruction from:

- accommodating individual needs to
- designing for variability from the beginning

A key insight is that:

small structural changes can significantly reduce cognitive load

Examples that stood out include:

- consistent course layout
- clear organization of materials
- use of simple engagement tools (fidgets, structured folders)

These are low-effort, high-impact changes that improve accessibility for all students.

9. Data-Driven Instructional Improvement

The final component of the session focused on using data to inform teaching decisions.

The process can be summarized as:

1. Assess student performance

2. Identify patterns or gaps
3. Adjust instruction or curriculum
4. Reassess for improvement

The key insight is:

Data is not just reporting—it is feedback on instructional effectiveness

This creates a continuous improvement loop at:

- course level
 - program level
 - institutional level
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10. Integrated Understanding

The most important realization from this session is that these concepts are not isolated—they form a connected system:

- **Maslow** → determines student readiness
- **Bloom's** → defines cognitive expectations
- **Performance-based learning** → defines how learning is demonstrated
- **Assessment** → measures that demonstration
- **Rubrics & feedback** → guide and refine performance
- **UDL** → reduces barriers to participation
- **Data** → informs continuous improvement

Together, they create a coherent instructional model focused on:

developing capability, not just delivering content

11. Application Moving Forward

Based on this session, I intend to:

- Re-evaluate competencies to ensure alignment with higher-order Bloom's verbs
 - Incorporate at least one additional performance-based assessment
 - Introduce or refine rubrics for clarity and feedback
 - Apply at least one UDL improvement to reduce cognitive load
 - Use AI tools as a starting point for curriculum design
 - Review assessment data more intentionally to guide improvements
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12. Closing Reflection

This session reinforced a critical shift in instructional thinking:

Effective teaching is not defined by how well content is delivered, but by how effectively students can demonstrate meaningful capability.

The frameworks presented provide a structured way to design, assess, and improve that capability over time.

This report itself reflects a performance-based approach, demonstrating integration of the frameworks presented.
